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Karen Horney's Personality Theory In Frodo Baggins' Life

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Abstract – The purpose of this essay is to use a psychological personality theory created by psychologist Karen Horney as a lens to view and analyze Frodo Baggins, a popular fictional character in the *Lord of the Rings*. Through a digestible analysis of a familiar fictional character's experiences, this paper will introduce concepts about personality, anxiety, and neurosis according to Karen Horney. It will follow Frodo through his journey in the saga and offer a rich application of theory in an ethical way. Horney's personality theory is useful for Frodo as he experiences basic anxiety and must navigate it through the mechanisms of the primary modes of relating and the basic orientations of life. He demonstrates neurotic behaviors but is ultimately able to achieve self-actualization following his triumphant return home.

Keywords: Karen Horney, Frodo Baggins, personality, neurosis, anxiety, psychology

Oftentimes in popular media, anxiety is portrayed as a disorder that causes sweating, heart palpitations, racing thoughts, nervousness, and more. "Anxiety, it is true, often appears simultaneously with physiological symptoms such as palpitations, perspiration, diarrhea, and quick breathing. These physical concomitants may appear with or without awareness of anxiety" (Horney, 1999, p. 193). Karen Horney, a respectable personality theorist, describes these feelings as a social and environmental force. Anxiety is a fundamental concept that is defined as a feeling of helplessness in a hostile world. Horney's theory on personality centers on anxiety and its potential growth to neurosis, yet it also describes some of the coping strategies and orientations of life that are instrumental for that anxiety to be contained. Frodo Baggins, a humble Hobbit from the Shire in Middle Earth, is a character from the *Lord of the Rings* (Tolkien, 1954a). A tragic event resulting in the loss of both his parents early in his life, as well as other social and environmental factors, cause Frodo Baggins to feel continual anxiety. As his story progresses, Frodo becomes less humble, reserved, and kind-hearted and more angry, neurotic, and anxious. While the story explains that a magic ring (created by an evil being) influences Frodo and causes this change, this plot device may serve as a tangible symbol and metaphor for the deeper, amorphous sources of uncertainty in an individual's life, which can be explained through the lens of personality as delineated by Karen Horney.

In *The Lord of the Rings*, Frodo lives a peaceful life. After inheriting his uncle's home and a magic ring, he was alerted to the dangerous and evil nature of the ring by his friend, a wizard named Gandalf. This wise wizard encouraged Frodo to take the ring to a grand council where it was decided that the ring must be destroyed in the fires of the volcano where the ring was formed, far away in the land of the enemy. Chosen as the ring bearer due to his innate sense of duty, bravery, and humility, Frodo then was given eight other companions, called the Fellowship of the Ring, to aid his quest. After traveling through dangerous mountains, mines, and forests, one companion tried to take the ring from Frodo. He narrowly escaped, however, and decided that he must continue his journey alone to not further burden the company. Another loyal Hobbit named Samwise Gamgee found and continued the journey with Frodo as his direct support, saving Frodo's life numerous times in their adventure. Though they fight and part ways due to another companion named Gollum later in the story, Samwise and Frodo reunite in the end. Frodo's arduous travels finish at the end of the films when he enters the Undying Lands, a place of eternal peace and happiness, free from anxiety and worry.

Anxiety

As a result of various cultural and social interactions, anxiety is a universal experience, leaving every individual to feel its effects at various points throughout the lifespan (Horney, 1962). Even as small children, we will all have situations in life that create and perpetuate feelings of anxiety. Basic anxiety is the pervading feeling of being lonely and helpless in a hostile world (Horney, 1945). This concept is very similar to Alfred Adler's concept of feelings of inferiority. Inferiority feelings arise from childhood dependence since we all begin life as inferior beings who are completely dependent on others for survival. This creates anxiety, which leads to fundamental experiences wherein we strive to overcome that sense of anxiety (Hjertaas, 2009). Both psychologists recognize the basic anxieties that plague the life experience of humans. Horney theorized that basic anxiety is anxiety about the environment as a whole, and that the environment is seen as a potential danger, differentiating between potential dangers and manifest dangers. The helplessness implicit in basic anxiety also works to motivate a person to seek out safety devices and coping strategies (Horney, 1999).

Towards the beginning of the film *The Lord of the Rings*, Frodo Baggins is chosen as the ring bearer to carry the One Ring to Mount Doom in Mordor. This is partly due to his generally stable and healthy personality traits and demeanor. Frodo is humble, simple, strong, and reliable. Though he is the least experienced in anything adventurous amongst the Fellowship of the Ring, Frodo has developed humility and social interest, which qualifies him to be the bearer of that ring. However, with such a demanding request, Frodo began to feel insecure. His uncertainty is evident as he states, "I will take the ring, though I do not know the way" (Tolkien, 1954a, p. 247). Karen Horney might label this insecurity as basic anxiety, or the sense of loneliness and despair from this very daunting task ahead of him. This anxiety remained evident in Frodo's journey throughout the films, and it ultimately progressed to an unhealthy level. The power of the ring, alongside his early life experiences, can explain the changes in Frodo's personality as he ages into young adulthood.

Some of the basic anxiety Frodo felt was due to another concept called basic evil. The concept of basic evil is an extension of and elaboration on Horney's concepts of anxiety and basic anxiety. A basic evil is any negative factor that provokes insecurity, makes a person feel alone, and is the result of a negative experience within social and environmental forces (Horney, 1937). These factors are not only malicious, but also those things that can allow you to feel helpless in the hostile world.

Even Frodo Baggins, a Hobbit from the Shire who lived a monotonous, safe life growing up, experienced basic evil. Because the Shire is quite secluded and peaceful, he did not experience much strife until a tragic event happened in his early childhood. At the age of 12, Frodo learned of a horrific boating accident that killed both of his parents, Drogo Baggins and Primula Brandybuck (Tolkien, 1954a). One interpretation of Horney's theory would suggest that the untimely death of his parents was a basic evil that altered his personality, and his desire to be loved and to matter. The normal warmth and affection that parents should give their children was missing in Frodo's life, which is what contributed to his basic anxiety (Horney, 1937). Following the accident that drastically altered his life, Frodo lived with his maternal family for the next nine years. At the age of 21 years old, Frodo was adopted by Bilbo Baggins, and he then moved in with his uncle to live at his home, Bag End (Tolkien, 1954a). The basic evil Frodo experiences as a result of this event is explained by Horney's theory. However, he would soon be led on an adventure full of mischief and danger that would uproot this new home life completely.

Frodo also sought out coping strategies in order to deal with the challenges that accompanied him. Coping strategies are plans that allow a person to endure the feelings of anxiety and to continue living in a normal way. These defensive attitudes that come from coping strategies may become exaggerated and can lead to inappropriate strivings, however. The prominent coping strategies in Karen Horney's theory are called the primary modes of relating.

Primary Modes of Relating

According to Horney, the primary modes of relating function as a way to relate to and connect with others in an attempt to evade the feelings of helplessness and continual anxiety, and there are three types (Horney, 1950). They are moving away, moving towards, and moving against. Moving away is when a person is retracting from the situation, and they are detached from the environmental or social influence. This is their way of coping with anxiety. Moving towards is when an individual is compliant and makes efforts to seek other people out to fulfill needs for affirmation and acceptance. These people desire to be loved in an attempt to cope with those feelings of anxiety. Moving against is a more aggressive approach, and this is when a person is more contentious, controlling, and hostile than the other orientations. They are also driven to succeed (Horney, 1945). All three of these modes of relating act as coping strategies to deal with anxiety and prevent neurosis.

These coping strategies are demonstrated in Frodo's life. When his parents died in a tragic boating accident, Frodo's basic orientation of life was to move towards his uncle Bilbo Baggins. Frodo had to rely on his uncle completely, and he sought out love and affirmation from Bilbo, and later his friends, particularly Sam. The next coping strategy Frodo used was moving away. At one point in the film, Frodo felt that he must continue the journey alone to not endanger or hurt any of the remaining members of the Fellowship of the Ring. To accomplish this goal, he begins rowing a boat into the depths of the sea alone, leaving behind all his companions. Frodo laments that the evil of the Ring is already at work in the Company, and he knows that the Ring needs to be separated from them before it continues to put the others in danger (Tolkien, 1954a). These actions demonstrate moving away needs because of the detachment and seclusion Frodo seeks out in this scene. On the other hand, in a scene showing Frodo, Samwise Gamgee, and Gollum traversing the dangerous world of Middle Earth, Frodo becomes irritated at Sam. After being woken up by Samwise Gamgee, who suggested they keep moving, Frodo is startled to see that there is no bread left for them to eat. This leads to an argument amongst the three companions. Ultimately, Frodo becomes mad at Samwise Gamgee and yells at him to get away and leave his presence (Tolkien, 1955). Frodo wanted to control the situation and felt threatened when Samwise offered to carry the ring for a little while. This led to Frodo exhibiting moving against coping strategies by getting angry and telling Samwise to go home. As mentioned, Frodo's life examples are a good representation of Horney's concept of primary modes of relating.

Orientations of Life

Underlying these primary modes of relating, which are primarily behavioral patterns in relationships, are Horney's concepts of the basic orientations of life. These are the self-effacing solution, which is an appeal to be loved, the self-expansive solution, which is an attempt at mastery, and the resignation solution, which is a desire to be free from others (Horney, 1987). These three orientations are the broader categories that the primary modes of relating fall under (Horney, 1950). These solutions are also coping strategies and can ultimately help a person have a healthy personality as they move between each of these solutions. Horney may suggest that Frodo Baggins uses a resignation solution when he moves away from the other members of the Fellowship and seeks to be on his own for the rest of the journey. He uses a self-expansive solution when he shows an exaggerated need for power and personal achievement at the end of the film at Mount Doom. When he finally gets to the mountain to throw the ring into the fire, he hesitates because of his weaknesses and succumbs to the craving for power from the ring. And lastly, he demonstrates the self-effacing solution at the end of the films when he accompanies more dominant friends to the Undying Lands, which shows his need for a dominant partner (Tolkien, 1955). These basic orientations of life intend to help each individual cope with anxiety and prevent neurosis.

Neurosis

Neurosis is caused by basic anxiety from interpersonal relationships (Horney, 1942). Neurotic patterns, which are persistent maladaptive behaviors, also come from basic anxiety or the overuse of the primary modes of relating. Neurotic individuals express one mode at the expense of other parts of their personality. They actively repress tendencies to react according to the other orientations. This repression is not successful, and those repressed tendencies continue to seek manifestation and increase the neurotic individual's anxiety. As the neurotic individual continues to choose one need or mode and overlook the others, a "vicious circle" develops, and the anxiety is never completely resolved (Horney, 1942). Normal and healthy individuals are able to balance orientations and express the primary modes of relating at the appropriate times. Those who succumb to neurosis are individuals who have been more severely hit by existing difficulties, particularly in their childhood. "A great frequency of neuroses and psychoses in a given culture is one of the indicators showing that something is seriously wrong with the conditions under which people live" (Horney, 1999, pp. 178–179). Frodo's loss of his parents is one such difficulty.

At an extraordinarily challenging time, Frodo expresses deep sadness that reveals the difficulties of taking the ring. He even wishes the ring never entered his possession and that the entire journey never happened (Tolkien, 1954a). In this scene from the films, Frodo dreams that he didn't have to endure the struggles and challenges of being hungry, being hunted by many groups of people, suffering from the ring, and more. At this point in time, Frodo also is becoming quite neurotic and damaged. Horney stated that neuroses are disturbances in an individual's relationships to oneself and others (Horney, 1950). Her theory might suggest that neuroses were very prevalent in his life and can be seen when Frodo tells Sam to leave his presence, and even when his relationships with Gollum and his own self become strained.

Neurotic Trends

From the ideas of neurosis and neuroticism, Karen Horney determined that 10 neurotic trends exist and can be used by any individual throughout the lifespan to prevent neurosis. According to her concept, the neurotic trends are not the source of danger, but the thing endangered, inasmuch as safety rests on their normally functioning operation. Anxiety emerges as soon as they fail to operate (Horney, 1999). These trends can be divided into categories that are contained by the three basic orientations of life. The first trend is an exaggerated need for affection and approval. The second trend is a need for a dominant partner. These two trends can fall under needing a self-effacing solution, which is an appeal to be loved, as well as relating to the moving toward mode of relating. The next five neurotic trends are an exaggerated need for power, a need to exploit others, an exaggerated need for social recognition and prestige, an exaggerated need for personal admiration, and an exaggerated ambition for personal achievement. These fall under the self-expansive solution, which is again a striving for mastery, and is related to the mode of relating by moving against others. The final three trends are a need to restrict one's life within narrow boundaries, an exaggerated need for self-sufficiency and independence, and a need for perfection and unassailability. These trends fall under the resignation solution, which is the desire to be free from others, as well as the moving away mode of relating (Horney, 1950). At certain times in the movies, Frodo relies on some trends more than the others, like the self-expansive solution trends where he moves away from others. This leads to the development of neurotic tendencies towards the middle and end of the films.

Real and Idealized Self

If engaging in neurotic trends, one may have a difficult time differentiating between the real self and idealized self, or in other words knowing who you truly are. If an individual is able to cope with the basic anxieties and challenges of life, they may be able to have a closely aligned real self and idealized self. This is similar to Carl Rogers' concept of congruence from humanistic psychology (Rogers, 1957). Karen Horney, too, theorizes about this, stating that the real self is how a person truly is, and that the idealized self is what an individual thinks they should be. The idealized self is useful as a motivating principle to help individuals achieve self-actualization. In a healthy and normal individual, the idealized self and the real self closely align because the idealized self is based on a realistic assessment of one's potential. In the neurotic individual, the real self and the idealized self are separated, leading to a difficulty in managing the anxieties that come from not being consistent with the idealized self (Horney, 1950). This makes it very difficult to achieve self-actualization. Additionally, as neurosis becomes more severe, a large number of potentialities of the real self may be useless for improvement. In an extreme neurosis, the individual may completely abandon the real self for an idealized glorified self. Horney termed this as alienation, or otherwise known as the devil's pact (Engler, 2014). In this state of alienation, a person identifies with the ideal self but also loses their strength in the real self. Also, when neurotic, individuals may place false needs in front of actual needs, which leads to a concept called the tyranny of the should. Under this condition of high anxiety, neurotic individuals deny the real self and become estranged from their true identity. The false needs create an idealized self that can be, at times, unattainable and unrealistic. This does not lead to a healthy personality, according to Karen Horney.

In Frodo's journey to deliver the ring, he becomes affected by the difficult standards of his idealized self. Frodo wants to be a courageous, selfless, strong, and an indestructible person that is able to deliver the ring without succumbing to its temptations. However, the longer he has the ring, the more his idealized self of being this hero drifts into a distant dream, not something that is realistic or presently achievable. This leads Frodo to spiral down into states of depression and anxiety, and it even furthers the neuroticism he began to develop midway through the trilogy. He places a heavy emphasis on how he should be the one and only ring bearer, and that pressure leads to insurmountable anxiety and neurosis from alienation and disconnection (Tolkien, 1954b).

Because Frodo ultimately obtained a dynamic of close real and idealized self towards the very end of the saga, it can be argued that he ultimately achieved self-actualization. Self-actualization, according to Karen Horney, is a comprehensive neurotic solution that satisfies, aids in painful feelings, and provides a fulfillment in life (Horney, 1950). To demonstrate self-actualization, Frodo, along with a few familiar faces, gets on a boat to sail to the Undying Lands, which is a place where the residents live in eternal bliss due to their calm and content state of being. It can be compared to a sort of heaven. Frodo isn't self-actualized simply because he goes there, but because before he leaves to enter those lands, he is able to acknowledge his real self, a broken but fulfilled Hobbit who doesn't feel at rest anywhere. He also sees that his ideal self is now concordant with that real self. Ultimately, this allows Frodo to become self-actualized. While there are many ways to interpret and

draw meaning from literature, Horney's perspective of self-actualization can be connected to these experiences.

Character Growth

Frodo Baggins was a character of great nobility, selflessness, and courage. He was a hero of heroes throughout the saga of *The Lord of the Rings*. As discussed, he was not always that way. In the beginning, Frodo could be better described as reserved, lazy, provincial, and small-minded. Some of these traits can be attributed to certain impactful life experiences with his parents and their deaths, as well as the events that soon followed. Though some of these traits persisted to the end of the films, Frodo underwent extensive changes both physically and mentally that altered his very personality. There were also negative traits obtained through carrying the ring for so long, including being paranoid, anxious, angry, and a selfish individual at times. Additionally, his failure to effectively use the basic orientations of life and primary modes of relating, the basic evil and anxieties felt from his parents dying, the struggles brought to him by the ring, and periods of time where his real self and idealized self were not aligned proved to increase his neuroticism. He became more and more unhealthy because of these behaviors, and that ultimately led to a potentially life-threatening mistake at Mount Doom in Mordor.

However, after he was able to rid himself of the ring and its powers, many of the issues he had with coping were able to be solved, and he was able to effectively use the modes of relating and orientations of life to combat the regular anxieties he felt from then on. Some of the characteristics that reflect Frodo's personality at the end of the film include bravery, resilience, courageousness, and wisdom. The natural character arc and progression of healthy personality to neurosis, and ultimately back to a healthy state of being was consistent with the story of Frodo Baggins. Karen Horney would suggest that people are able to make changes in order to better cope with the basic anxieties of life. Her theory states that the balanced use of all three basic orientations of life will provide a healthy personality, and self-actualization is possible through consistent efforts to do so.

Karen Horney's personality theory can offer much in terms of understanding the self and our relationships with others. This perspective, along with other interpretations, is valid and useful for examining literature and real-life scenarios. Anxiety, coping strategies, and basic orientations of life are all prevalent in the human experience. Our task is to escape the continual feeling of anxiety that is key to being human. Frodo Baggins, once a solitary and stable person living in the Shire, becomes more and more neurotic through the progression of the films *The Lord of the Rings*. His coping strategies fail, and the viewers can clearly see his physical and non-physical changes that come from those failures. Frodo may be a bit damaged and neurotic towards the end of the films, but it was a sacrifice worth making. Ultimately, he was able to achieve self-actualization after demonstrating more healthy choices and coping behaviors after ridding himself of the ring. These personal changes highlight some of the key concepts of personality through Horney's eyes. Frodo, though a fictional character, isn't that much different from you and me. His challenges are, in part, our challenges. His successes are similar to those of a regular person's. Perhaps the greatest lesson to be learned from examining Frodo through Karen Horney's personality theory is this: There are ways to cope with the basic anxieties of life, one can improve from a state of neurosis, and there is still good left in this world. When the call for adventure comes, be sure to answer it. It may take you the furthest away from home you've ever been.

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